

Mugar Memorial Library

Site: Mugar Memorial Library

Date: 02/20/2026

Time (Start–End): 19:00-22:00

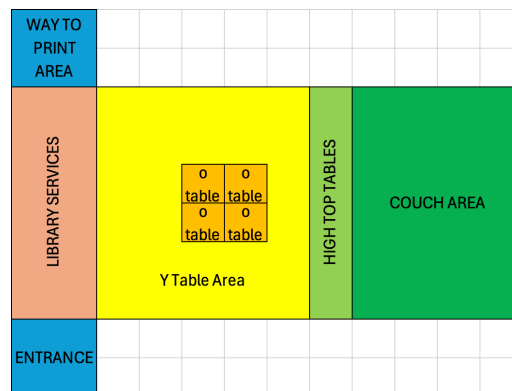
Location within Library (floor / section): Ground Floor, Main Lounge

Duration of Observation: 3 Hours

1. Spatial & Sensory Description

Physical Layout

- Furniture arrangement:



- Table types (individual vs group):
 - Y shaped tables,
 - Dalyarra someone abraham
 - I shaped tables,
 - o shaped tables,
 - rectangular high-top tables,
 - coffee tables for l shaped and arm-chair couches.
- Lighting (natural/artificial/harsh/soft):
 - White Fluorescent Light

- Windows? Visibility outside?
 - Almost None, very limited
- Placement of outlets:
 - Y tables
 - On Tables
 - Under Tables
 - On some pillars
 - On brick walls
 - Cannot hold larger power bricks due to overusage
- Bookshelves:
 - None at this area.

Soundscape

- Background noise:
 - Low humming noise from HVAC systems probably
- Volume shifts:
 - None noticed
- Whisper frequency:
 - People tend to talk out loud rather than whisper.
- Silence patterns:
 - Mostly stops when someone starts eating or snacking
- Interruptions:
 - Food
 - Group working

Smell

- None, or Anthropologist has a smelling problem

Tactile / Atmosphere

- Temperature:
 - around 20 degrees celcius
- Crowded vs empty?
 - At around 60% capacity
- Tight seating vs spacious?
 - Y/I tables have at most 2 meters between them
 - Each Y table has either two 3-person areas and one 1-person area or three 1-person area.
 - Each I table has 2 I table areas.
- Tension vs calm?
 - Calm

Analytical Prompt:

What does this design seem intended to encourage?

There are no clocks hung in the area and the only windows are tinted so that there are no natural light changes. Without sunlight or clock cues, your brain can't anchor itself to the time of day.

The space appears to encourage self-regulation rather than formal enforcement. Despite the absence of visible policing or staff intervention, the environment remains calm and orderly. This suggests that individuals internalize the expectations of the space and monitor their own behavior, relying on social norms and mutual awareness rather than strict authority to maintain discipline.

What behaviors does it discourage?

The fluorescent lighting and upright seating discourage lounging or resting behavior, as the furniture does not support fully relaxed postures.

The tight spacing between tables discourages loud conversation or expressive social behavior, as such actions would be immediately noticeable to others in proximity.

2. Who Is Here?

Demographic Observations

- Approximate age range:
 - 18-25
- Dress patterns:
 - Most wear simple comfortable and warm clothes like sweatpants and hoodies.
 - Approx. one fifth of students wear BU apparel.
 - Most people have large/puffy coats due to weather conditions
- Bags:
 - Mostly Backpacks are used.
 - Some females use handbags.

Body Language

- People are more slouched than upright.
- People who are working alone are using head/earphones.
- Some people are stretching
- Some people are showing fatigue signals

Analytical Prompt:

How do people “perform” being students here?

Students perform academic identity through visible productivity: laptops open, headphones in, backpacks at their feet, and extended physical presence. Comfortable clothing suggests long study sessions, while BU apparel signals institutional belonging. Fatigue and stretching gestures indicate sustained effort. The collective effect is a shared performance of seriousness and disciplined focus.

3. Behavior & Activity Patterns

What Are People Doing?

- Reading
- Typing
- Watching videos

Emotional Indicators

- Stress signals
 - forehead rubbing
 - rapid typing
 - people playing with their hair
- Relief
 - There are none
- Frustration
 - Erasing repeatedly
 - Mostly with people studying numerical lessons

4. Communication Norms

Verbal Communication

- Quite loud for a library study area
- No staff interventions

Non-Verbal Communication

- Everyone is minding their own business

5. Movement & Flow

- Who enters frequently?
 - People grab food and come back sometimes

- How long do people stay?
 - No one has left yet
- Are seats competitive?
 - No
- Do people cluster near outlets?
 - No
- Do certain tables fill first?
 - No

Analytical Prompt:

How does architecture organize behavior?

Not at this moment

6. Your Positionality

- Where are you sitting?
 - On the high-top tables
- Do people notice you writing?
 - Yes
- Do you feel intrusive?
 - Definatly
- Do you blend in?
 - I hope so
- Does your major/background change what you notice?
 - I don't think so

REFLECTION

Several patterns stood out during my observation. The most dominant theme was disciplined productivity. Although this area of Mugar is not labeled as a “silent” zone, the atmosphere remained calm and orderly without visible enforcement. There were no staff interventions, no explicit policing, and no posted clocks. The tinted windows and fluorescent lighting removed natural time cues, creating a stable, almost suspended environment. This appeared to encourage extended focus and temporal immersion. Students seemed to regulate themselves rather than rely on authority. The physical layout, segmented Y and I tables spaced closely but not crowded, created a form of quiet co-presence: people worked individually but in awareness of others. Loud or disruptive behavior would immediately stand out, which subtly reinforces conformity. The space therefore felt less like a collaborative lounge and more like a productivity-oriented environment built around discipline and endurance.

The experience of observing was unexpectedly uncomfortable. Sitting at a high-top table while actively taking notes made me feel visible and slightly intrusive. I became hyper-aware of my own movements, typing noise, and posture. Time felt distorted. Without clocks and natural light shifts and it became difficult to understand how long I had been in the same place. The low hum of the HVAC system became louder the longer I stayed, driving me a deranged, and small behaviors, like someone rubbing their forehead or repeatedly erasing a calculation, became highly noticeable. Observing in this way required slowing down and noticing details I would usually ignore while studying.

I also noticed physical signals of exhaustion that I would normally overlook. Many students were slouched, stretching, or displaying fatigue behaviors. Headphones signaled isolation, even while sitting in shared space. Backpacks at people’s feet, large winter coats draped over chairs, and laptops open for extended periods all reinforced a shared ritual of academic labor. The absence of bookshelves in this area highlighted how the space functions more as a digital workspace than a traditional library archive. This observation revealed how architecture organizes behavior: outlets embedded in tables prioritize laptop use, fluorescent lighting sustains alertness, and tight spacing encourages self-monitoring.

Viewed as a system, the space takes in students and laptops, operates on norms of discipline and productivity, and outputs completed assignments, along with visible signs of stress and fatigue. While limited small-group collaboration occurs, the dominant impression is one of disciplined isolation rather than collective engagement. The architecture does not force silence, but it subtly produces it through design.